

SDANJAY KUMAR



Liquor is Quicker

CHANDIGARH An ugly face-off between the Shiromani Akali Dal (SAD) and the BJP over the violence-marred Panchayat elections in Punjab may have been averted by top leaders, but the coalition partners seldom fight shy of adhering to the true spirit of coalition politics in sharing the spoils of power.

Making the most of the newly-tailored liberal excise policy, ministers and MLAs of the ruling combine have benefitted from discretionary allocation of L-13 licences for wholesale trading of Punjab

Medium Liquor by private distilleries. There are 110 L-13 outlets in the state run by 10 distilleries which get the state excise department's quota to supply 70 per cent of liquor sold through 6,000 retail liquor shops. On the face of it, the distilleries have the discretion to distribute L-13 permits for sale of liquor at wholesale rates. But the distillery owners oblige politicians by doling out the lucrative permits as per their recommendation. "It's an internal arrangement between the distilleries

ON A HIGH: An alcohol outlet in Punjab

and the ruling politicians," says a top excise official.

In a carefully-calibrated exercise to curry favour with the ruling legislatures, SAD president Sukhbir Singh Badal reportedly pulled strings with the distilleries to have the outlets allotted in the name of their kith and kin. As each outlet generates a profit of Rs 15 lakh a year without any major investment, the beneficiaries have a reason to uncork the champagne. "It's like a fixed monthly dividend," says a beneficiary minister.

Barring two BJP ministers, most Cabinet members and MLAs are understood to have availed the Badal-brokered quota of licenses pegged to the legislature strength of each partner. Not surprisingly, despite their coalition relations touching a new low in the wake of the bad blood created by the Panchayat slugfest, the ruling partners continue to be spiritedly high in sharing the fishes and loaves of power.

by Ramesh Vinayak

SIGNPOSTS

EXTENDED: The ban on the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam, for another two years, by the Indian Government. The LTTE was banned in 1992 after the assassination of Rajiv Gandhi.



DIED: R.N. Jayagopal, Kannada film lyricist, actor and director who had written over 1,600 songs

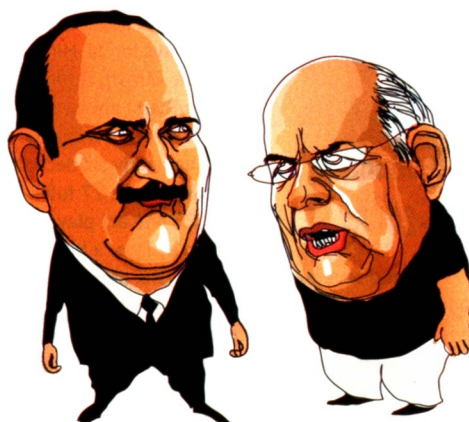
in a career spanning 40 years. He was 73.

SELECTED: Sridhar Kamble, 17, a Dalit farmer's son, by NASA to train as an astronomer, following his feedback on the space agency's findings on galaxy evolution.

AWARDED: To Pam Kwatra, the Ellis Island Medal of Honor Award for her humanitarian work and for building bridges between India and the US. The award was conferred by the National Ethnic Coalition of Organizations in New York.

VIS-A-VIS ANBUMANI RAMADOSS health minister versus MAHESH BHATT Filmmaker

“What hasn't been achieved in the last 40 years in healthcare has been achieved by the UPA Government and in my tenure.”



SAURABH SINGH

“His comments are juvenile. Villages don't have healthcare, rural health sector is in a mess but his concern is limited to the film industry.”

EPILOGUE: Perhaps it's time that the star-struck minister looks beyond the smokescreen of stars.